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EDITORIAL

Values, Encounter, and the Limits of What Can Be Done

On the Focus of the Second Issue

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ABSTRACT

The second issue of the first volume of the Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology shifts its focus from the methodological questions of the first issue toward therapeutic and counseling practice. Under the theme “Meaning, values, and existential challenges in psychotherapeutic practice,” it brings together papers that relate central concepts of logotherapy to contemporary treatments and settings of care. A theoretical paper compares the concept of values in acceptance and commitment therapy with Viktor E. Frankl's categories of values. A review describes meaning-centered psychotherapy in palliative care and appraises its evidence base. A contribution on practice and teaching outlines principles of logotherapeutically informed counseling for burnout and crises of meaning. A book review reassesses Frankl's account “Man's Search for Meaning” from a contemporary perspective. The editorial sketches the common point of reference of these papers: the question of how psychotherapy can deal with what cannot be changed, and which role values and meaning play in this respect. It also recalls the journal's editorial principles, in particular the clear labeling of didactic case vignettes as constructed teaching examples.

Keywords: values · logotherapy · psychotherapeutic practice · palliative care · editorial

From the State of Research to Practice

The first issue of this journal was devoted to the question of how logotherapy can be situated in the context of contemporary psychotherapy research. The present second issue turns more strongly to therapeutic and counseling practice. Its focus is “Meaning, Values, and Existential Challenges in Psychotherapeutic Practice.” This change of perspective does not signify a departure from the standard of scientific rigor; rather, it responds to the observation that conceptual imprecision can have particularly far-reaching consequences in practice.

A unifying motif of the contributions is the question of how psychotherapy can deal with what cannot be changed. In addition to creative values and experiential values, Frankl (1946) described attitudinal values, which are realized in a person’s stance toward unalterable suffering. Yalom (1980) named death, freedom, isolation, and meaninglessness as the ultimate concerns of existence that every psychotherapy must sooner or later confront.

For psychotherapeutic practice, this question is of immediate significance. Many treatment approaches are geared toward bringing about change: symptoms are to decrease, dysfunctional patterns to dissolve, capacities to grow. Yet not everything that burdens people can be changed. Chronic and life-limiting illnesses, losses, irreversible life decisions, or structural conditions of the working world set limits to what can be achieved therapeutically. It is precisely at these limits that the question of meaning and values gains weight.

The Contributions to This Issue

The Cognitive Behavioral Therapy and Contextual Approaches unit compares the concept of values in Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (Hayes et al., 2012) with Frankl’s categories of values and asks where genuine convergences exist and where there are merely family resemblances. The Psycho-Oncology and Palliative Psychology unit presents a review of Meaning-Centered Psychotherapy, which is among

the most carefully investigated meaning-centered interventions (Breitbart et al., 2015).

The contribution from practice and teaching by the Counseling Psychology unit develops the main features of logotherapeutically oriented counseling for burnout and crises of meaning. It works with a teaching vignette explicitly identified as constructed and carefully distinguishes counseling from the treatment of mental disorders. The issue concludes with a review of Frankl's account *… trotzdem Ja zum Leben sagen* (Man's Search for Meaning), which asks about the enduring significance, but also the limitations, of this widely read book.

The contributions show in different ways that engaging with these limits need not mean resignation. It does, however, require an attitude that neither offers comfort prematurely nor glorifies suffering as a means of finding meaning. Frankl himself emphasized that avoidable suffering is to be eliminated and that only unavoidable suffering offers an opportunity to realize attitudinal values (Frankl, 1946).

Outlook

With this issue, the first volume of the journal comes to a close. The editors thank the participating units for their contributions and for their willingness to commit to the journal's principles of integrity: cautious reporting of empirical findings, transparent identification of theoretical premises and constructed case examples, and consistent orientation toward verifiable sources. We look forward to continuing the discussion in the coming volume.

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